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THINK SMALL

In my first faltering steps down my career path, I landed a job with a firm that was a predecessor of the present-day Harris Associates, at that time a small Chicago brokerage house that also looked after some of its clients' portfolios. I knew a bit about stocks and bonds; I had, as Oscar Levant once put it, a smattering of ignorance. But Irving Harris, whose firm it was, took me under his wing, trained me as a security analyst, and eventually turned me into a portfolio manager.

My first analytic assignment was to go see a company called H. M. Harper, located in a Chicago suburb. It made nuts and bolts, literally—stainless steel nuts and bolts. I had worked in a machine shop for a time, so I knew a turret lathe when I saw one and felt reasonably comfortable when one of the firm's managers took me into the shop. My surprise came when he led me into a second building, which housed a brand-new machine (one the company had been working on for a couple of years) that could make stainless steel extrusions. Stainless steel is extremely difficult to extrude, but the company had finally created a machine that could turn out various structural shapes; the first orders were coming from the air-